

Chapter 5 Why Nations go to War: Nationalist Leaders and Democratic Peace

Abstract

Although the literature deems impersonal forces, such as regime type and international system, the main causes of interstate war, this chapter brings political leaders to the forefront. This chapter argues that the conflict-proneness of nationalist leaders explains why some countries defy expectations of peaceful relations under liberal democracy. Nationalism makes democratic dyads war-prone, offsetting the peace-building effects of democratic institutions. This chapter tests this novel argument using a mixed-methods research design. A cross-national, time-series quantitative analysis offers evidence that when nationalist leaders rule democracies, they are more likely to engage in conflict. Qualitative studies of territorial disputes between South Korea and Japan and the 1999 India-Pakistan War also confirm conflictual relationships among nationalist democracies. To combat rising nationalism, the security community needs a new roadmap to peace.